

EXPERIMENT 3

Application Building using Zia Assistant

1. Aim

To develop a simple Expense Management application in Zoho Creator with the assistance of Zia Assistant, and to understand how an AI assistant can support application building and expense data management.

2. Introduction

Zoho Creator is a low-code application development platform that provides visual tools for creating forms, reports, workflows, and applications. Zia Assistant adds AI-based assistance that can help users build and work with applications more efficiently. In this experiment, an Expense Management application is created to record, organize, and analyze expense information.

3. Objectives of the Study

- To understand the basic process of building an application in Zoho Creator.
- To create an Expense Management form with suitable fields.
- To use Zia Assistant to support application development and expense analysis.
- To organize expenses using categories, payment methods, and reports.
- To create and preview a functional Expense Management application.

4. Procedure

1. Log in to the Zoho Creator platform.
2. Create a new application named Expense Management.
3. Create an Expense form using the Form Builder.
4. Add fields such as Expense ID, Expense Date, Expense Description, Category, Amount, Payment Method, Merchant Name, and Notes.
5. Configure suitable field types and mark essential fields as mandatory.
6. Use Zia Assistant where applicable to assist with application creation and data-related tasks.
7. Create suitable reports or views for recorded expense information.
8. Save and preview the application to verify the form and its components.
9. Enter sample expense records and verify that they are stored correctly.

5. Illustrative Example

An Expense Management System can be used to record daily expenses in an organized form. The application stores the amount, category, payment method, date, and other details so that expense information can be reviewed and analyzed.

5.1 Implementation using Zoho Creator

- Expense ID – Auto Number field for generating a unique expense identifier.
- Expense Date – Date field for recording the date of the expense.
- Expense Description – Single Line field for entering the expense details.
- Category – Dropdown field for selecting Food, Transport, Shopping, Bills, Entertainment, Education, Healthcare, or Other
- Amount – Currency/Number field for recording the amount spent.
- Payment Method – Dropdown field for selecting Cash, UPI, Debit Card, Credit Card, or Bank Transfer.
- Merchant Name – Single Line field for recording the merchant or vendor name.
- Notes – Multi Line field for adding additional information.

5.2 Application Building with Zia Assistant

Zia Assistant can be used to assist the application-building process and to work with expense information. It can help users frame application requirements, generate useful summaries, and support analysis of recorded expense data.

The screenshot displays the Zoho Creator form builder interface for an 'Expense Management' application. The top navigation bar includes 'Expense Management', 'Expenses', a '+' icon, and a 'Done' button. The main workspace is divided into three sections: 'Basic Fields', 'Field Properties', and a bottom navigation bar.

Basic Fields: This section contains a grid of field types: Name, Email, Address, Phone, Single Line, Multi Line, Number, Date, Time, Drop Down, Radio, Checkbox, Lookup, and File Upload. The 'Expense ID' field is selected, showing a value of '123' and an 'Auto generate' option.

Field Properties: This section shows the configuration for the 'Expense ID' field. It includes:

- Field name:** Expense ID
- Field link name:** Expense_ID
- Hide field information:** A link to hide the field information.
- Validation:** A checkbox for 'Mandatory' is checked, and a checkbox for 'Unique' is unchecked.
- Display Fields:** Checkboxes for 'Prefix' and 'Suffix' are both unchecked.
- Initial Value:** A radio button for 'Default' is selected, and a radio button for 'User defined' is unselected. Below these is an 'Auto generate' button.

Bottom Navigation Bar: This bar contains icons for 'Form', 'Reports', 'Pages', 'Workflow', and 'Settings'. The 'Form' icon is highlighted. On the right side of the bar are 'Help' and 'Next' buttons.

Figure 1: Zoho Creator Expense Management form builder.

5.4 Zia Assistant – Expense Analysis

Zia Assistant can be used to work with the information stored in the Expense Management application. Example tasks include summarizing expenses, identifying frequently used categories, and presenting the recorded information in a concise form.

5.5 Example Analysis

- Monthly expense summary – Provides a concise view of recorded expenses.
- Category analysis – Helps identify categories with higher spending.
- Expense search – Helps locate relevant records using natural-language requests.
- Data summary – Converts multiple records into an easier-to-understand overview.

6. Advantages and Limitations

Advantages

- Low-code environment makes application creation simpler.
- Zia Assistant provides AI-based assistance for selected tasks.
- Expense data can be organized in structured forms and reports.
- The application can be extended with additional workflows and reports.

Limitations

- Zia capabilities depend on the features available in the platform.
- Complex requirements may still need manual configuration or scripting.
- AI-generated outputs should be reviewed before being used for important decisions.

7. Result

Thus, an Expense Management application was successfully designed in Zoho Creator with the assistance of Zia Assistant. The experiment helped in understanding how a low-code platform and AI-assisted features can be combined to build and manage an application for recording and analyzing expenses.